

Accessibility review: National History Museum

****Observer:**** Mia Tursman

****Date:**** 2026-05-11

****Overall compliance:**** 63% of rated items met (10 met, 3 not met, 3 partial, 1 N/A)

Labels & text

-  Labels use plain English — short sentences, active voice — ****Met****
-  Legible font used — no all-caps or decorative scripts — ****Met****
-  Type size appropriate for the viewing distance — ****Partial****
 - > Many historical story captions were an appropriate size, however oftentimes image labels were much smaller and harder to read
-  High contrast between label text and background (70%) — ****Met****
-  Labels printed on matte, non-glare surfaces — ****Partial****
 - > Some labels were placed behind glass and they had a shadow on the texts as well
-  Wall labels centered at approx. 54 in. (readable seated & standing) — ****Met****
-  Label positions consistent throughout the exhibition — ****Not met****
 - > Some labels in display cases were tilted forward so they could be read from any angle, however some were flat down, facing upward which would be difficult for a user in a wheelchair to read. There is no reason why they could not all be tilted slightly forward
-  Alternative formats available: Braille, large print, or audio guide — ****Not met****
 - > One small activity had a braille option telling you where to throw your paper away, but it was not present anywhere else in the museum. The audio guide seemed to only be for certain artifacts that did not have written descriptors, but not for general information about the museum or the history. It also would have been impossible to tell which number on the audio guide should be pressed if you could not see it written behind the glass
-  100–300 lux of light on all label surfaces — ****Partial****
 - > Certain rooms were dimly lit to help preserve the artifacts, and the Egypt room was almost impossible to read on many surfaces. Other than that it was good everywhere else.

Safety & content

-  Both visual and audible fire alarms are present — ****Met****
-  Accessible emergency exits clearly marked with access symbols — ****Met****
-  Exhibition addresses multiple intellectual levels and sensory channels — ****Met****
-  People with disabilities represented respectfully in exhibit content — ****Met****
-  Labels use person-first language throughout — ****N/A****
 - > I am confused by what this means

---*Checklist based on the [Smithsonian Guidelines for Accessible Exhibition Design](<https://www.sifacilities.si.edu/sites/default/files/Files/Accessibility/accessible-exhibition-design1.pdf>)*